

The Educator's Complete Guide to

Claude AI & Cowork

How to Save Time, Teach Smarter, and Make a Greater Impact

A comprehensive guide for K–12 educators, instructional coaches,
curriculum specialists, and school leaders

By The Rooted Learner

therootedlearner.com

March 2026

Table of Contents

- Chapter 1** What Is Claude and Why Should Educators Care?
 - Chapter 2** Which Plan Fits Your Teaching Life?
 - Chapter 3** Privacy, Ethics, and FERPA: What Educators Need to Know
 - Chapter 4** The Three Models and When to Use Each
 - Chapter 5** Setting Up Claude Desktop, Cowork, and Your Settings
 - Chapter 6** The Educator's Toolkit Inside Claude
 - Chapter 7** Personalizing Claude for Teaching and Planning
 - Chapter 8** Chat vs. Cowork: When to Use Which
 - Chapter 9** How to Talk to Claude: Prompting for the Classroom
 - Chapter 10** Your First Cowork Session (Step by Step)
 - Chapter 11** Skills: Building Your Teaching Assistant's Playbook
 - Chapter 12** 10 Real-World Claude + Cowork Scenarios for Educators
 - Chapter 13** Connecting Claude to Your Workflow
 - Chapter 14** From Beginner to Power User: Your Growth Path
 - Chapter 15** Tips, Limitations, and What's Next
-

Chapter 1: What Is Claude and Why Should Educators Care?

The Teacher Time Crisis

If you are a teacher, you already know the math does not work. Between lesson planning, grading, parent communication, IEP documentation, data analysis, professional development requirements, and the actual act of teaching, there are never enough hours. A 2024 RAND Corporation study found that U.S. teachers work an average of 53 hours per week, with less than half of that time spent on direct instruction. The rest goes to planning, administrative tasks, and communication.

Claude is an AI assistant built by Anthropic that can help you reclaim significant portions of that non-instructional time, so you can redirect your energy toward the work that made you become a teacher in the first place: connecting with students and facilitating meaningful learning.

What Claude Actually Is

Claude is a large language model, meaning it is an AI system trained on vast amounts of text that can understand and generate human language. But here is what matters for you as an educator: Claude can read, write, analyze, brainstorm, organize, draft, revise, differentiate, and collaborate with you on nearly any text-based task you face in your professional life.

Think of Claude less like a search engine and more like a highly knowledgeable teaching assistant who is always available, never judges your questions, and can adapt to your specific grade level, subject area, standards framework, and teaching style.

What Claude Can Do for Educators

Here is a snapshot of what educators are using Claude for right now:

- **Lesson Planning:** Generate unit plans, daily lesson outlines, learning objectives aligned to standards, and pacing guides in minutes rather than hours.
- **Differentiation:** Create tiered assignments, scaffolded reading passages, modified assessments, and enrichment activities for diverse learners.
- **Assessment Design:** Draft formative and summative assessments, build rubrics, write constructed-response items, and generate answer keys with rationale.
- **Parent Communication:** Write parent emails, conference notes, progress updates, and newsletter content in your voice and tone.
- **IEP and 504 Support:** Draft present levels of performance, generate accommodation suggestions, and create progress monitoring templates.
- **Report Card Comments:** Produce individualized, strengths-based narrative comments for every student.
- **Professional Development:** Summarize research articles, build PD session outlines, create workshop materials, and draft grant applications.

- **Data Analysis:** Upload assessment data and ask Claude to identify trends, group students by skill level, and suggest intervention strategies.
- **Curriculum Mapping:** Align units across the year to ensure standards coverage, vertical alignment, and logical sequencing.
- **Content Creation:** Build anchor charts, vocabulary lists, discussion questions, bell ringers, exit tickets, and review games.

Why Claude Over Other AI Tools?

Claude is designed with safety, helpfulness, and honesty as core principles. It excels at following complex, nuanced instructions (such as your specific school context and teaching preferences), handling long documents (up to 200,000+ tokens), and producing high-quality, structured output. For educators who need an AI that can understand the difference between third- and eighth-grade reading levels and adjust accordingly, Claude is a powerful fit.

What Claude Is Not

It is important to set realistic expectations from the start:

- **Claude is not a replacement for your professional judgment.** It is a tool that amplifies your expertise. You are still the educator in the room.
- **Claude is not always correct.** Like all AI models, Claude can produce inaccurate information (sometimes called “hallucinations”). Always review and verify output before using it with students or families.
- **Claude is not a student-facing tool by default.** This guide focuses on how you, the educator, use Claude to enhance your professional practice. Student-facing AI use raises additional considerations regarding age appropriateness, supervision, and district policy.
- **Claude does not have access to the internet in real time by default in all modes,** but it can search the web when that feature is enabled in chat.

Chapter 2: Which Plan Fits Your Teaching Life?

Claude offers several plan tiers. The right one depends on how much you plan to use it, whether you are an individual teacher or part of a team, and what features matter most to your workflow.

Plan Comparison for Educators

Plan	Cost	Best For	Key Features
Free	\$0	Exploring Claude for the first time; occasional use	Access to Claude Sonnet; limited daily messages; basic features, including Projects and Artifacts
Pro	\$20/month	Individual teachers using Claude daily for planning and communication	5x more usage than Free; access to Opus models; extended thinking; Cowork; Claude Code; web search; Google Workspace integration
Max (5x)	\$100/month	Power-user educators, instructional coaches, and curriculum directors	5x Pro usage; Opus 4.6 with 1M context window; priority access; advanced features
Max (20x)	\$200/month	Full-time AI-integrated workflow; heavy daily use	20x Pro usage; maximum priority; zero-latency access
Team	\$25–\$150/user/month	Grade-level teams, departments, and school buildings	Shared Projects; admin controls; higher limits per seat
Enterprise	Custom pricing	District-wide deployment	SSO; dedicated support; SAML; tailored integrations; compliance features

The Educator's Decision Framework

Start Free If...

- You have never used Claude before and want to explore before committing.
- You only need AI help a few times a week for quick tasks like drafting an email or brainstorming discussion questions.
- Your district provides another AI tool, and you want to compare.

Go Pro If...

- You plan to use Claude daily for lesson planning, differentiation, or communication.
- You want access to the most capable models (Opus 4.6) for complex tasks like curriculum mapping or IEP drafting.

- You want to use Cowork for multi-step, file-based tasks, such as building a full unit plan with assessments.
- You need Google Workspace integration to pull from your Drive, Calendar, or Gmail.

Consider Max If...

- You are an instructional coach serving multiple teachers and constantly generating differentiated materials.
- You are a curriculum director building resources for an entire grade band or content area.
- You regularly exceed Pro usage limits due to the volume of your work.

Explore Team or Enterprise If...

- Your grade-level team or department wants to share prompts, Projects, and templates.
- Your school or district is ready for a coordinated rollout with admin controls.
- You need compliance features, SSO, or data governance for district IT approval.

Educator Tip: Start with Pro

For most individual teachers, the Pro plan at \$20 per month is the sweet spot. It gives you access to the best models, Cowork, and enough usage for a full day of planning and communication. Think of it as less than the cost of one classroom supply run, and it will save you hours every week. You can always upgrade later.

Chapter 3: Privacy, Ethics, and FERPA — What Educators Need to Know

Before you type a single prompt, you need to understand the privacy and ethical landscape. This chapter is not optional. It is the foundation that makes everything else in this guide responsible and sustainable.

The Golden Rule: Never Enter Student PII

Personally Identifiable Information (PII) includes student names, ID numbers, dates of birth, addresses, parent names, disability status, grades tied to a specific student, disciplinary records, and any other information that could identify an individual student. Under FERPA (Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act), sharing this information with a third-party tool without proper authorization is a violation.

The simplest rule to follow: Never type a real student's name, ID number, or any identifying information into Claude. Use pseudonyms, generic descriptors ("Student A," "a third-grader reading below grade level"), or anonymized data. This single practice protects you and your students.

Key Laws Educators Should Know

FERPA (Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act)

- Protects the privacy of student education records at institutions receiving federal funding.
- Requires consent before disclosing personally identifiable information from education records.
- Applies to all K–12 public schools and most private schools.
- When using Claude: Do not input student records, grades tied to names, IEP details with identifying information, or any content that could identify a specific student.

COPPA (Children's Online Privacy Protection Act)

- Regulates online collection of personal information from children under 13.
- The 2025 amendments shifted to opt-in consent requirements and stricter data retention rules.
- When using Claude, this applies primarily when students are interacting directly with it. For teacher-only use (which this guide focuses on), COPPA is less directly relevant, but remain aware if your district explores student-facing implementations.

State-Level AI Policies

- As of early 2026, nearly all U.S. states have published AI guidance documents for K–12 education.
- Many states reference FERPA, COPPA, CIPA, and IDEA as baseline compliance frameworks for AI use.

- About 12 states specifically emphasize data minimization, meaning you should avoid inputting PII into AI systems even if the tool claims to protect it.
- Check your state department of education website and your district's acceptable use policy before integrating Claude into your professional workflow.

Practical Privacy Guidelines for Educators Using Claude

Do This	Not This
"I have a student reading at a DRA level 16 who struggles with fluency..."	"Johnny Smith in my 2nd period reads at a DRA 16..."
"Write an accommodation plan for a student with ADHD and a 504."	"Write accommodations for Maria Garcia, DOB 3/15/2015, ID# 45892."
"Analyze this anonymized data set" (remove names before uploading)	Upload a gradebook with student names and grades
"Draft an email to a parent about a student's behavior."	"Draft an email to Mrs. Johnson about Tyler's behavior at Maple Elementary."
Use generic role descriptions: "a multilingual learner," "a student with an IEP."	Use identifying details: specific diagnoses, addresses, family situations with names

Ethical Considerations Beyond Privacy

Bias Awareness

AI models can reflect biases present in their training data. Be aware that Claude's suggestions around student grouping, behavior expectations, or family communication may inadvertently carry assumptions. Always apply your professional judgment and cultural competence as a filter.

Academic Integrity

This guide is about your professional use of Claude, not student use. However, if you are creating materials with Claude, consider transparency: some educators note on their materials that AI was used as a drafting tool. This models responsible AI use for your students and colleagues.

Over-Reliance

Claude is a co-pilot, not an autopilot. The pedagogical decisions, student relationships, cultural responsiveness, and in-the-moment instructional adjustments are yours. Use Claude to handle the repetitive and time-consuming tasks, so you have more capacity for the irreplaceable human work of teaching.

Before You Start Checklist

1. Review your district's AI acceptable use policy. 2. Confirm your state's AI guidance for educators. 3. Commit to never entering student PII. 4. Decide on your approach to transparency about AI-assisted work. 5. Bookmark Anthropic's usage policy at anthropic.com/policies.

Chapter 4: The Three Models and When to Use Each

Anthropic offers three model tiers within the Claude family. Understanding the differences will help you choose the right model for each task, balancing speed, depth, and your usage budget.

The Model Lineup

Model	Speed	Depth	Best Educator Use Cases
Claude Haiku 4.5	Fastest	Good for straightforward tasks	Quick parent email drafts; simple question generation; vocabulary list creation; bell ringer ideas; reformatting existing text; spelling and grammar checks on your own writing
Claude Sonnet 4.6	Fast	Strong reasoning and nuance	Lesson planning; differentiated activity creation; rubric building; unit outline drafting; assessment item writing; newsletter content; analyzing short texts; professional emails
Claude Opus 4.6	Slower	Deepest reasoning and analysis	Curriculum mapping across a full year; complex IEP present levels and goal writing; multi-layered data analysis; long-document review and synthesis; building comprehensive unit plans with embedded assessments; research synthesis for PD presentations

A Teacher's Decision Guide

Think of it this way: Haiku is your quick sticky-note helper. Sonnet is your daily planning partner. Opus is the curriculum consultant you bring in for the big projects.

Use Haiku When...

- The task is simple, and speed matters more than depth.
- You need a quick first draft that you will heavily edit anyway.
- You are doing high-volume, low-complexity tasks (generating 20 vocabulary sentences, converting a list to a different format).
- You want to conserve your usage allocation for bigger tasks later.

Use Sonnet When...

- You need Claude to carefully consider standards alignment, learning progressions, and differentiation.
- You are doing your daily lesson planning and want quality output on the first try.
- You are writing anything that will go directly to families or administrators.
- You need web search capabilities for current information.

Use Opus When...

- The task requires deep reasoning across many variables (building a scope and sequence for an entire course).
- You are uploading long documents and need thorough analysis (a 50-page curriculum guide, an entire novel for literature circles, a set of state standards).
- You are doing extended, multi-step projects in Cowork.
- The stakes are high, and you need Claude's most nuanced, careful output.

Usage Tip

On the Pro plan, Sonnet is your workhorse. Use it for 80% or more of your daily tasks. Reserve Opus for the weekly or monthly big-ticket projects where the deeper reasoning makes a real difference. This approach keeps you well within your usage limits.

Chapter 5: Setting Up Claude Desktop, Cowork, and Your Settings

Getting Started with Claude

Step 1: Create Your Account

- Go to claude.ai and sign up with your email address.
- If you plan to use the Pro plan, you can subscribe immediately or explore the Free tier first.
- Use your professional email if your district allows it, or a personal email if you prefer to keep your AI tools separate from district-managed accounts.

Step 2: Download the Desktop App

- Visit claude.ai/download to get the Claude Desktop app for Mac or Windows.
- The desktop app is required for Cowork. You cannot access Cowork solely through a web browser.
- Cowork launched on Mac in January 2026 and Windows in February 2026 with full feature parity.

Step 3: Explore the Interface

When you open Claude, you will see two primary modes:

- **Chat:** The standard conversation interface. You type, Claude responds. This is where you will do most quick tasks.
- **Cowork (Desktop App):** An agentic mode where Claude can access your local folders, create and edit files, execute multi-step tasks, and work more independently. Think of it as the difference between texting a colleague and handing them a project folder.

Configuring Your Settings

Key Settings to Configure

- **Web Search:** Enable this to let Claude search for current information. Useful when you need up-to-date standards documents, current events for lesson hooks, or recent research.
- **Code Execution and File Creation:** Enable this to let Claude run code and generate files (documents, spreadsheets, presentations) directly in your conversation.
- **Artifacts:** Keep enabled. This is how Claude creates interactive content, code, documents, and visualizations within your conversation.
- **Memory:** Enable this so Claude remembers your preferences, grade level, subject area, and working style across conversations.
- **Projects:** Use Projects to organize your work by subject, unit, or purpose (e.g., a “3rd Grade ELA” Project, a “Parent Communication” Project).

The Customize Menu: Your Teaching Profile

The Customize menu (found in Settings) allows you to set persistent instructions that Claude will follow across all your conversations. This is one of the most powerful features for educators, and we will go deeper in Chapter 7.

For now, here is a starter custom instruction to enter:

Starter Custom Instruction

I am a [grade level] [subject] teacher at a [public/private/charter] school. My students are [brief description of student population]. I follow [state] standards and use [curriculum/program names]. When I ask for help with lesson planning, default to [your lesson plan format]. Keep language professional but warm. When creating student-facing materials, target a [grade] reading level. I prefer [bullet points / narrative paragraphs/templates] for planning documents.

Setting Up Cowork

In the Claude Desktop app, click “Cowork” in the sidebar. You will be asked to grant Claude access to specific folders on your computer.

Recommended Folder Structure for Educators

- Create a main folder: Teaching-with-Claude
- Inside it, create subfolders: Lesson-Plans, Assessments, Communication, Data, PD-Materials, Templates
- Grant Cowork access to this main folder.
- Do NOT grant access to folders containing student PII, gradebooks with names, or confidential records.

Important Safety Note

Cowork can read, create, edit, and delete files in any folder you give it access to. Only grant access to folders where you are comfortable with Claude operating. Keep your confidential student data in separate, non-shared folders. Claude will ask before taking significant actions, but it is always best to limit access proactively.

Chapter 6: The Educator's Toolkit Inside Claude

Claude comes loaded with features that map directly to educator workflows. Here is what each one does and how to use it in your teaching life.

Feature Overview

Feature	What It Does	Educator Use Case
Projects	Organized workspaces with custom instructions and uploaded reference files	Create a Project per unit, course, or purpose. Upload your standards, curriculum guides, and templates so Claude always has your context.
Artifacts	Interactive documents, code, and content that Claude creates within the conversation	Claude builds lesson plan templates, interactive timelines, rubrics, vocabulary games, and data visualizations as Artifacts you can download or iterate on.
File Upload	Attach documents, images, PDFs, and spreadsheets for Claude to read	Upload your curriculum map, a student writing sample (anonymized), assessment data (names removed), or a textbook chapter for analysis.
Web Search	Claude searches the internet for current information	Find the latest state standards updates, current events for lesson hooks, or recent research to cite in a PD presentation.
Memory	Claude remembers details across conversations	Claude learns your grade level, subject, preferred formats, school name, and recurring preferences so you do not have to repeat yourself.
Extended Thinking	Claude reasons through complex problems step-by-step before responding	Use for complex curriculum mapping, multi-variable data analysis, or nuanced IEP goal writing where you need Claude to think deeply.
Research	Claude conducts deep, multi-source research and delivers a comprehensive report	Research evidence-based reading interventions, find peer-reviewed studies for a grant application, or survey best practices for a new program.
Connectors	Link Claude to Google Workspace, Slack, and other tools	Pull lesson plan drafts from Google Docs, reference your Google Calendar for planning, or search your Drive for existing materials.

Projects: Your Digital Filing Cabinet

Projects are the organizational backbone of your Claude workflow. Each Project can hold custom instructions (a system prompt that Claude follows for every conversation within that Project) and uploaded files (reference documents Claude can access).

Recommended Projects for Educators

- **Course/Subject Projects:** "5th Grade Math," "8th Grade ELA," "K Science." Upload your scope and sequence, standards, and preferred lesson plan template.
- **Communication Project:** Upload your school letterhead template, your preferred email tone guide, and examples of past communications you liked.
- **Assessment Project:** Upload your rubric templates, item specifications, and assessment philosophy docs.
- **PD and Leadership Project:** For instructional coaches or team leads building professional development materials.
- **IEP/504 Project:** Upload anonymized templates, your state's IEP format requirements, and sample goal banks.

Artifacts: Your Content Workshop

When Claude creates substantial content (a lesson plan, a rubric, a data visualization, a React-based interactive), it appears as an Artifact in the right panel of your conversation. You can copy, download, or iterate on Artifacts.

Educator-Specific Artifact Ideas

- Interactive vocabulary matching games (React Artifacts)
- Standards-aligned rubrics in table format
- Weekly newsletter templates
- Data visualizations from assessment results
- Scope and sequence documents
- Differentiated reading passage sets at multiple Lexile levels

Chapter 7: Personalizing Claude for Teaching and Planning

This chapter is the single biggest unlock for educators using Claude. The more context you give Claude about who you are, what you teach, and how you work, the less time you spend re-explaining yourself and the higher quality output you get from the very first response.

Custom Instructions: Your Teaching DNA

Custom instructions are persistent preferences that Claude follows across all conversations (or within a specific Project). Set these once, and every future interaction starts from a place of understanding.

What to Include in Your Custom Instructions

- **Your Role and Context:** Grade level, subject area(s), school type, student population demographics (general, not PII), and years of experience.
- **Standards Framework:** Which standards you follow (Common Core, NGSS, state-specific, WIDA for ELLs, etc.) and whether you want Claude to reference specific standard codes.
- **Curriculum and Programs:** Adopted curriculum (Eureka Math, CKLA, Amplify Science, etc.), supplemental programs (SIPPS, Foundations, Heggerty), and assessment systems (MAP, DRA, i-Ready, DIBELS).
- **Preferred Formats:** How you like lesson plans structured (I Do / We Do / You Do? Workshop model? 5E?), whether you prefer bullets or narrative, and your template preferences.
- **Student Considerations:** General characteristics like “high percentage of multilingual learners,” “wide range of reading levels,” “inclusion classroom with co-teaching model.”
- **Communication Style:** Warm and conversational? Formal? Brief and direct? How do you want Claude to write parent emails, colleague messages, and student-facing materials?
- **Specific Preferences:** Always include accommodations for ELLs, always add extension activities, always align to specific standards, and always include a formative check.

Memory: Teaching Claude Your Patterns

Claude's Memory feature lets it remember details from your past conversations. Over time, Claude learns things like your preferred rubric format, that you teach a double-block ELA period, your school's PBIS language, and that you always want sentence frames included for your multilingual learners.

How to Use Memory Effectively

- Tell Claude directly: “Remember that I teach a 90-minute literacy block with 30 minutes of small-group instruction.”
- Correct Claude when it gets something wrong: “Actually, we use NGSS, not Common Core, for science. Please remember this.”

- Review your stored memories periodically in Settings to ensure accuracy.
- You can ask Claude to forget specific details if your context changes (e.g., new school, new grade level).

Project-Level Custom Instructions

In addition to your global custom instructions, each Project can have its own set of instructions. This is incredibly powerful for educators who teach multiple subjects or grade levels.

Example: 3rd Grade ELA Project Instructions

Project Instructions Example

This Project is for 3rd-grade ELA lesson planning and materials. Standards: Maryland College and Career Ready Standards for ELA. Curriculum: CKLA (Core Knowledge Language Arts) supplemented with trade books. Lesson format: Mini-lesson (10 min) → Guided/Independent Practice (25 min) → Share/Debrief (5 min). Reading levels in this class range from DRA 14 to DRA 38. Always include: vocabulary with kid-friendly definitions, sentence frames for discussion, and a formative exit ticket. Differentiation: Provide scaffolded, on-level, and enrichment versions of independent practice when asked.

Uploaded Reference Files

Within each Project, upload the documents Claude needs to do its best work:

- Your scope and sequence or pacing guide
- The relevant section of your state standards
- Your preferred lesson plan template
- Sample materials you have created that reflect your style
- School or district style guides for communication
- Rubric templates and assessment frameworks

Power Move

Upload your best lesson plan, the one you are most proud of, and tell Claude: "This is my gold-standard lesson plan. When I ask you to create lesson plans, match this structure, tone, and level of detail." This single action will dramatically improve every lesson plan Claude generates for you.

Chapter 8: Chat vs. Cowork — When to Use Which

Understanding when to use Claude's Chat mode versus Cowork mode is the difference between having a helpful assistant and having a full project partner.

Chat Mode: Your Quick-Turn Partner

Chat is the standard Claude conversation interface, available on the web (claude.ai), mobile apps, and the desktop app. It is a back-and-forth dialogue where you send a message, Claude responds, and you iterate.

Use Chat When...

- You need a quick draft of something (parent email, discussion questions, bell ringer).
- You are brainstorming ideas and want to think out loud with Claude.
- You have a single, contained task (write a rubric, generate vocabulary sentences, explain a concept at a different reading level).
- You want to upload a single file and get feedback or analysis.
- You are on your phone or tablet and need help on the go.

Chat Strengths for Educators

- Fast turnaround on simple tasks.
- Easy to iterate: ask for changes, adjustments, or alternatives.
- Web search integration for current information.
- Artifacts for interactive or visual content.
- Works on any device.

Cowork Mode: Your Project Partner

Cowork is available in the Claude Desktop app. It is fundamentally different from Chat. In Cowork, Claude operates with much more autonomy. You give Claude a task (or a series of tasks), Claude makes a plan, executes it, and checks in with you along the way. Cowork can read and write files on your computer, create documents, and handle multi-step workflows.

Use Cowork When...

- You need to produce multiple related files (a full week of lesson plans, a unit plan with assessments, a set of differentiated reading passages).
- The task has many steps that build on each other (analyze data, group students, create targeted activities for each group).
- You want Claude to work with your existing files (revise your lesson plan template, update your scope and sequence, reformat your rubrics).
- You have a big project you would normally spend an entire planning period or weekend on.

- You want to queue up multiple tasks and let Claude work through them while you do something else.

Cowork Strengths for Educators

- Multi-step task execution without constant back-and-forth.
- Direct file creation and editing on your computer.
- Built-in skills for creating Word documents, presentations, spreadsheets, and PDFs.
- Parallel task processing: queue up several tasks and let Claude work through them.
- Global and folder-specific instructions for consistent output.

The Decision Matrix

Scenario	Use Chat	Use Cowork
Draft a parent email	✓	
Generate 5 discussion questions	✓	
Build a full 3-week unit plan with daily lessons		✓
Create differentiated versions of an assignment at 3 levels		✓
Brainstorm project-based learning ideas	✓	
Analyze assessment data and create intervention groups		✓
Quick grammar check on your own writing	✓	
Produce a PD slide deck with handouts and facilitator notes		✓
Write report card comments for 25 students		✓
Look up a current event for tomorrow's lesson hook	✓	

Usage Note

Cowork uses more of your usage allocation than Chat because multi-step tasks require more computation. Use Chat for quick tasks and reserve Cowork for the bigger projects where its autonomous, file-based workflow really shines. This keeps your usage balanced throughout the week.

Chapter 9: How to Talk to Claude — Prompting for the Classroom

The quality of Claude's output is directly tied to the quality of your input. This chapter gives you practical frameworks and templates for writing prompts that get you what you actually need, the first time.

The TEACHER Prompting Framework

Use this framework as a mental checklist every time you write a prompt for a teaching task:

Letter	Element	Example
T	Task — What do you want Claude to do?	Create a 5-day lesson plan
E	Expectations — What format, length, or structure?	Use the I Do / We Do / You Do format with time blocks
A	Audience — Who is this for?	3rd graders reading at a range of DRA 14–38
C	Context — What should Claude know about the situation?	We are in Week 3 of a fiction unit using CKLA
H	How — Any specific approaches, frameworks, or methods?	Include sentence frames for ELLs and Depth of Knowledge levels 2–3
E	Examples — Can you show Claude what good looks like?	Attach your best lesson plan or describe the format
R	Restrictions — What should Claude avoid?	Do not use worksheets; avoid activities requiring technology the school does not have

Prompting Principles for Educators

1. Be Specific About Standards

Weak: "Create a math lesson on fractions."

Strong: "Create a 45-minute lesson for 4th graders on comparing fractions with unlike denominators, aligned to CCSS 4.NF.A.2. Use manipulatives (fraction bars) in the guided practice. Include a 5-question exit ticket."

2. Specify the Reading Level and Audience

Weak: "Write a passage about the water cycle."

Strong: "Write a 250-word informational passage about the water cycle for 5th graders at a Lexile range of 740–880. Include a text feature (diagram description or bold vocabulary). Write 3 text-dependent questions at DOK levels 1, 2, and 3."

3. Give Claude a Role

Assigning Claude a role focuses its output:

- "You are an experienced 6th-grade science teacher who specializes in inquiry-based instruction."
- "You are a reading intervention specialist familiar with the Science of Reading and SIPPS."
- "You are a school counselor drafting a social-emotional learning lesson for K–2 students."

4. Ask for Differentiation Explicitly

Claude will not differentiate unless you ask. Be specific about what differentiation looks like for your context:

- "Provide three versions: approaching, on-level, and advanced."
- "Include sentence frames and a word bank for multilingual learners."
- "Add an extension challenge for early finishers."
- "Simplify the directions to a 2nd-grade reading level for the modified version."

5. Iterate, Don't Start Over

Your first prompt gets you 70–80% of the way there. Use follow-up prompts to refine:

- "This is great, but make the guided practice more interactive."
- "Add a turn-and-talk to the mini-lesson."
- "Revise the exit ticket to be two questions instead of five."
- "Keep the structure but change the text to a nonfiction passage about volcanoes."

Prompt Templates for Common Educator Tasks

Lesson Plan Prompt Template

Lesson Plan Prompt

Create a [duration]-minute lesson plan for [grade level] [subject] on [topic]. Align to [standard code]. Use the [lesson structure format] format. Student context: [reading levels, ELL percentage, inclusion notes]. Include: learning objective, materials list, teacher script for the mini-lesson, guided practice activity, independent practice, and a formative assessment (exit ticket with answer key). Differentiation: provide scaffolded, on-level, and enrichment versions of the independent practice.

Assessment Prompt Template

Assessment Prompt

Create a [formative/summative] assessment for [grade level] [subject] on [unit/topic]. Align to [standards]. Include: [number] multiple-choice items at DOK 1–2, [number] constructed-response items at DOK 2–3, and a rubric for the constructed responses. The assessment's reading level should be [Lexile/grade level]. Include an answer key with a rationale for each correct answer.

Parent Communication Prompt Template

Parent Email Prompt

Draft a professional, warm email to a parent about [topic: positive update/behavior concern / academic progress / upcoming event]. Tone: [warm and encouraging/direct but kind / celebratory]. Length: [brief — 3–4 sentences / moderate — 1 paragraph / detailed]. Include: [specific observations, next steps, invitation for follow-up]. Do not include real student names; use [Student] as a placeholder.

Chapter 10: Your First Cowork Session — Step by Step

Let us walk through a complete Cowork session from start to finish. We will build a differentiated lesson plan, which is one of the most universally useful tasks for any educator.

Before You Begin

- Make sure you have the Claude Desktop app installed and up to date.
- Create your Teaching-with-Claude folder with a Lesson-Plans subfolder.
- Have a specific lesson in mind (topic, grade, standards, duration).
- Grant Cowork access to your Teaching-with-Claude folder.

Step-by-Step Walkthrough

Step 1: Open Cowork and Set the Context

Click “Cowork” in the sidebar of the Claude Desktop app. You will see a message input area similar to Chat, but with the added context of your folder access.

Start with a context-setting message:

Your First Message

I’m a 3rd-grade teacher preparing a lesson on main idea and key details in informational text, aligned to RI.3.2. My literacy block is 60 minutes. I use a mini-lesson, guided practice, independent practice, and a share-out structure. My class includes 6 multilingual learners (WIDA levels 2–4) and 4 students with IEPs who need modified text. Please create a complete lesson plan in a Word document and save it in my Lesson-Plans folder.

Step 2: Watch Claude’s Plan

Claude will show you the plan before executing. You might see something like:

- Read existing files in the Lesson-Plans folder to understand your template format.
- Create a lesson plan document with all components.
- Include differentiated materials for three tiers.
- Save the completed document.

Review the plan and approve or redirect. You might say: “That looks good, but also include an exit ticket as a separate section at the end.”

Step 3: Let Claude Work

Once you approve, Claude will execute. You can watch its progress, step away, or queue up additional tasks. For example, while Claude works on the lesson plan, you could add:

- “Also create a vocabulary list for this lesson with kid-friendly definitions and sentence frames.”

- “And draft a quick email to send home about our informational text unit.”

Step 4: Review the Output

When Claude finishes, check your Lesson-Plans folder. You should find your document(s) ready to review. Open them and look for:

- Alignment to the standard you specified.
- Correct reading level and age-appropriateness.
- Differentiation that matches your student descriptions.
- Practical, realistic activities you could actually do in your classroom with your available materials.

Step 5: Request Revisions

No lesson plan is perfect on the first draft. Use follow-up messages to refine:

- “The guided practice needs more scaffolding. Add a graphic organizer for students to use during the read-aloud.”
- “Change the independent practice text from animals to weather, since that connects to our science unit.”
- “The exit ticket is too long. Make it two questions instead of four.”

Step 6: Save Your Template

Once you have a lesson plan you love, save it as a template. You can tell Claude: “Save a copy of this as a template in my Templates folder, with placeholders where the topic-specific content goes.” This template becomes a reference for every future lesson plan.

Time Comparison

A task like this — a fully differentiated lesson plan with multilingual learner supports, modified text, exit ticket, and vocabulary list — might take 60–90 minutes to create from scratch. With Cowork, you can have a strong first draft in 5–10 minutes, with another 10–15 minutes of review and revision. That is a potential savings of over an hour per lesson.

Chapter 11: Skills — Building Your Teaching Assistant's Playbook

Skills are reusable instruction sets that teach Claude how to perform specific tasks the way you want them done. Think of Skills as training your teaching assistant once so they can repeat the task consistently.

What Are Skills?

In Cowork, Skills are specialized instructions that Claude can reference when performing tasks. They contain best practices, templates, formatting rules, and domain-specific knowledge that improve the quality and consistency of Claude's output.

Built-In Skills

Cowork comes with built-in Skills for common file types:

- Document creation (Word .docx files)
- Presentations (PowerPoint .pptx files)
- Spreadsheets (Excel .xlsx files)
- PDF creation and manipulation

These Skills mean Claude already knows how to produce professional-quality documents in standard formats. You do not need to explain how to format a Word document — Claude already knows.

Creating Custom Skills for Education

The real power comes from creating your own Skills that encode your specific teaching practices. Here are examples of educator-specific Skills you might create:

Skill: Lesson Plan Generator

- Your specific lesson plan format and structure.
- Required components (objective, standards, materials, procedures, assessment, differentiation).
- Your preferred instructional models (workshop, 5E, gradual release).
- Differentiation requirements (always include ELL supports, always provide three tiers).

Skill: Report Card Comment Writer

- Your school's comment format and character limit.
- Strengths-based language requirements.
- Required elements (academic progress, social-emotional growth, areas for growth, goals).
- Tone and voice guidelines.

- Subject-specific language for each content area.

Skill: Assessment Builder

- Item types and format specifications.
- DOK level distribution requirements.
- Standards alignment protocol.
- Answer key format with rationale.
- Rubric format for constructed-response items.

Skill: Parent Communication

- Email templates for different situations (positive, concern, event, progress update).
- Tone and language guidelines.
- Required elements (greeting, specific observation, next step, closing).
- Things to always include and things to always avoid.

How to Create a Skill

In the Cowork interface, you can set folder-specific instructions or global instructions that function like Skills. For a more formalized approach:

- Create a SKILL.md file in your Teaching-with-Claude folder that contains your instructions for a specific task type.
- Structure the file with clear sections: Overview, Required Components, Format Rules, Examples, and Things to Avoid.
- Tell Claude: "When I ask you to create a lesson plan, follow the instructions in the Lesson-Plan-Skill.md file in my Templates folder."

Skill Development Strategy

Start with your most time-consuming, repetitive task. If you write report card comments for 25 students three times a year, that Skill alone could save you 10–15 hours per year. Build one Skill at a time, test it, refine it, and then move to the next. Within a month, you will have a library of Skills that make your daily workflow dramatically faster.

Chapter 12: 10 Real-World Claude + Cowork Scenarios for Educators

These scenarios span grade bands, subjects, and roles. Each one shows a realistic educator workflow and the prompting approach that makes it work.

Scenario 1: Weekly Lesson Planning (Elementary)

The Task

A 2nd-grade teacher needs to plan a full week of math lessons on two-digit addition with regrouping.

The Approach

Open Cowork, grant access to your Lesson-Plans folder, and provide context about your math block structure, adopted curriculum, and student levels. Ask Claude to create five daily lesson plans as Word documents, each following your standard format, with manipulative-based activities and a daily formative check.

What Claude Delivers

Five Word documents in your folder, each containing an objective, standards alignment, materials list, warm-up, direct instruction script, guided and independent practice, and an exit ticket. Differentiation notes are embedded for approaching, on-level, and advanced groups.

Scenario 2: Differentiated Reading Passages (Middle School)

The Task

A 6th-grade ELA teacher needs the same informational content at three Lexile levels for a science integration lesson on ecosystems.

The Approach

In Chat, upload the original grade-level passage and ask Claude to rewrite it at Lexile 600–700 (approaching), 800–900 (on-level), and 1000–1100 (advanced). Request that all three versions cover the same key content and vocabulary, with text-dependent questions for each.

What Claude Delivers

Three passages with the same core content and vocabulary, adjusted for sentence complexity, vocabulary load, and text structure. Each includes four text-dependent questions at appropriate DOK levels.

Scenario 3: IEP Goal Writing and Progress Monitoring

The Task

A special education teacher needs to draft measurable IEP goals for a 4th-grade student with a specific learning disability in reading.

The Approach

In Chat, describe the student's current performance levels (without PII) and current assessment data. Ask Claude to generate measurable annual goals with short-term objectives, aligned to grade-level standards, and written in your state's required format. Also, request a progress-monitoring schedule and a data-collection template.

What Claude Delivers

Three annual goals with measurable criteria, timelines, short-term benchmarks, and a progress monitoring template you can populate with student data.

Scenario 4: Report Card Comments at Scale

The Task

A 5th-grade teacher needs to write individualized narrative report card comments for 28 students across four subject areas.

The Approach

In Cowork, provide Claude with your comment format, character limit, and required elements. Then create an anonymized data file: "Student A: reading at grade level, strong in discussion, needs support with written expression. Student B: above grade level in math, quiet in class, excellent homework completion." Ask Claude to generate individualized comments for each.

What Claude Delivers

A document with 28 sets of comments (four subjects each), all following your format, all strengths-based, and all addressing individual growth areas. Review and personalize as needed.

Scenario 5: Assessment Design with Data Analysis

The Task

A 7th-grade math teacher needs to create a unit assessment on ratios and proportions, administer it, and then analyze the results to form intervention groups.

The Approach

Phase 1 (Chat): Ask Claude to create the assessment with a mix of item types, aligned to standards, with an answer key. Phase 2 (Cowork): After the assessment, upload the anonymized results (Student A scored 85%, Student B scored 62%, etc.) and ask Claude to analyze the data, identify patterns by standard, and recommend small-group intervention groups with targeted reteaching activities.

What Claude Delivers

A complete assessment document, an answer key with rationale, and post-assessment analysis with student groupings and targeted activity suggestions for each group.

Scenario 6: Parent Communication Suite

The Task

A new teacher needs templates for common parent communication scenarios: positive behavior update, academic concern, conference invitation, field trip permission, and weekly newsletter.

The Approach

In Cowork, provide Claude with your school's communication tone, your preferred level of formality, and any required elements (school header, contact info, sign-off). Ask Claude to create five email templates as Word documents, each with placeholder fields for student-specific details.

What Claude Delivers

Five professional email templates in your folder, each with the right tone, necessary components, and clearly marked placeholders. Ready to customize and send.

Scenario 7: Professional Development Session Design

The Task

An instructional coach needs to design a 90-minute PD session on formative assessment strategies for the math department.

The Approach

In Cowork, ask Claude to create a facilitator guide (Word document), a participant handout (Word document), and a slide deck (PowerPoint) for the session. Provide the session objectives, the audience (8 math teachers, grades 6–8), and the key strategies you want to cover. Ask Claude to include interactive activities, discussion protocols, and a feedback form.

What Claude Delivers

Three files in your folder: a detailed facilitator guide with timing, talking points, and transition notes; a clean participant handout; and a slide deck ready for presentation.

Scenario 8: Curriculum Mapping and Vertical Alignment

The Task

A curriculum director needs to map the K–5 ELA reading standards to ensure vertical alignment and identify gaps.

The Approach

In Cowork, upload the state ELA standards documents for K–5. Ask Claude to create a spreadsheet mapping each standard strand across grade levels, identifying the progression, noting where skills spiral, and flagging any gaps or redundancies. Request a narrative summary highlighting key findings.

What Claude Delivers

An Excel spreadsheet with a complete standards map by strand and grade level, color-coded for progression, and a Word document summarizing the key alignment findings with recommendations.

Scenario 9: Multilingual Learner Support Materials

The Task

An ELD teacher needs to create WIDA-aligned language objectives and scaffolded materials for a content-area lesson on the American Revolution.

The Approach

In Chat, specify the WIDA proficiency levels of your students, the content objectives from the social studies curriculum, and the language domains you want to target (reading and writing). Ask Claude to write language objectives at WIDA levels 1–3, create a scaffolded graphic organizer, build a tiered word wall with visual descriptions, and draft sentence frames for a structured discussion.

What Claude Delivers

WIDA-aligned language objectives, a graphic organizer with built-in scaffolds, a tiered vocabulary resource, and discussion sentence frames at three proficiency levels.

Scenario 10: Grant Application Drafting

The Task

A school librarian wants to apply for a literacy grant to refresh the classroom library.

The Approach

In Chat, upload the grant application guidelines (or describe the requirements) and provide context about your school's demographics, current library resources, and the impact you envision. Ask Claude to draft each section of the application, including the needs statement, project description, budget narrative, and evaluation plan. Use Research mode to find supporting statistics and citations.

What Claude Delivers

A complete first draft of the grant application with data-supported arguments, a realistic budget narrative, and a measurable evaluation plan. Ready for your review and personalization.

Chapter 13: Connecting Claude to Your Workflow

Claude becomes even more powerful when it can access the tools you already use. Connectors and integrations let Claude reach into your Google Workspace, calendar, and other platforms.

Google Workspace Integration

If you are in a Google school (and most K–12 schools are), this integration is essential.

Google Drive

- Claude can search your Drive for existing lesson plans, templates, and documents.
- You can reference files in Drive without manually downloading and uploading them.
- Particularly useful for finding that unit plan from last year that you want to update.

Google Calendar

- Claude can reference your calendar to understand your schedule.
- Useful for planning: “What do I have this week?” or “Schedule my planning time around my meetings.”

Gmail

- Claude can reference emails for context.
- Draft responses based on email threads.
- Particularly useful for managing parent communication volume.

How to Enable Connectors

- In Claude (web or desktop), go to Settings.
- Look for Connectors or Integrations.
- Authenticate with your Google account (or other supported services).
- Grant the specific permissions Claude requests.

District IT Note

If your school uses Google Workspace for Education, your IT department may need to approve Claude as a connected application. Check with your technology coordinator before connecting your school Google account. You can always use a personal Google account instead if district approval is pending.

MCP (Model Context Protocol) Integrations

MCP is the protocol that allows Claude to connect to external tools and services. On paid plans, you have access to a growing ecosystem of connectors, including Notion, Slack, and other

productivity tools. For educators, the most relevant connectors today are Google Workspace tools, but the ecosystem is expanding rapidly.

Making the Most of Integrations

The key to effective integration is using Claude as your central hub rather than switching between tools:

- Instead of searching Google Drive manually, ask Claude to find your Q2 reading assessment results.
- Instead of writing an email in Gmail and then asking Claude to review it, draft the entire email in Claude and then send it.
- Instead of checking your calendar and then planning separately, ask Claude to review your week and suggest the best times to plan specific tasks.

Chapter 14: From Beginner to Power User — Your Growth Path

You do not need to learn everything at once. Here is a progressive roadmap that builds your skills over time.

Week 1–2: Foundation

Goals

- Set up your Claude account and choose your plan.
- Configure your custom instructions with your basic teaching context.
- Complete five Chat conversations for simple tasks: draft an email, generate discussion questions, create a vocabulary list, write a rubric, and brainstorm lesson ideas.

Success Metric

You can open Claude and get useful output for a quick task in under 2 minutes.

Week 3–4: Building Confidence

Goals

- Create your first Project with uploaded reference documents.
- Use the TEACHER prompting framework for a complete lesson plan.
- Try uploading a file for Claude to analyze or build upon.
- Experiment with different models (Haiku for quick tasks, Sonnet for planning).

Success Metric

You use Claude for at least one planning task every day, and the output requires minimal editing.

Month 2: Going Deeper

Goals

- Set up Cowork and complete your first multi-file project.
- Build your first custom Skill (start with your most repetitive task).
- Connect Google Workspace and use Claude as your planning hub.
- Use Claude for complex tasks: a full unit plan, an assessment suite, or data analysis.

Success Metric

You have saved at least 3–5 hours per week compared to your previous workflow.

Month 3–4: Power User

Goals

- Build a library of 3–5 custom Skills covering your core workflows.
- Create Projects for each major area of your work.
- Use Cwork for weekly batch processing (next week's lesson plans, report card comments, assessment creation).
- Share your approaches with colleagues and offer informal support.

Success Metric

Claude is integrated into your daily workflow. You have a library of Skills and Projects. Colleagues are asking you how you get so much done.

Month 5+: Expert and Leader

Goals

- Lead a PD session or workshop introducing colleagues to Claude.
- Develop department-wide or grade-level-wide shared approaches.
- Advocate for responsible AI policy at the building or district level.
- Explore advanced use cases: curriculum mapping, data-driven instruction cycles, grant writing, and program evaluation.

Success Metric

You are not just using Claude — you are helping transform how your team approaches planning, assessment, and communication.

Growth Mindset Reminder

If you have ever taught a student to read, you already know that mastery is not linear. There will be days when Claude's output misses the mark. There will be prompts that do not work the way you expected. That is not failure — that is the revision process. Iterate on your prompts the same way you would iterate on a lesson plan. Every "bad" output teaches you something about how to write a better prompt next time.

Chapter 15: Tips, Limitations, and What's Next

Top 10 Tips from Educators Using Claude

- **1. Start your day with Claude.** Spend 10 minutes each morning generating your daily materials instead of scrambling at lunch or after school.
- **2. Use Projects religiously.** The 30 minutes you spend setting up a project save hours over the course of a semester.
- **3. Upload your best work as examples.** Claude learns your style faster from examples than from descriptions.
- **4. Do not accept the first draft.** Always iterate at least once. The second or third version is almost always better.
- **5. Batch your Cowork tasks.** Instead of using Cowork for one lesson plan, queue up an entire week at once.
- **6. Save your best prompts.** Create a prompt library document and copy in the prompts that consistently give you great results.
- **7. Use Claude for the tasks you dread.** Report card comments, data entry, email drafting — let Claude handle the work that drains your energy.
- **8. Always verify facts and citations.** Claude can hallucinate. If it cites a statistic, standard, or research finding, double-check it.
- **9. Protect your students.** Never enter PII. Use anonymized descriptors. Make this an automatic habit.
- **10. Share what you learn.** Teaching your colleagues about Claude multiplies its impact across your entire school.

Known Limitations

Being honest about what Claude cannot do builds trust and prevents frustration:

- **Hallucinations:** Claude can generate plausible-sounding but incorrect information. Always verify standards codes, research citations, historical facts, and any claim that seems too specific.
- **No Real-Time School Data:** Claude does not connect to your SIS, LMS, or gradebook. You need to provide the data manually (always anonymized).
- **Usage Limits:** All plans have usage caps. You may hit limits during heavy use, especially with Cowork and Opus. Plan your biggest tasks for the beginning of your usage cycle.
- **Not a Replacement for Expertise:** Claude does not know your students. It does not see their faces, hear their questions, or feel the energy in your room. Your professional judgment is irreplaceable.
- **Evolving Technology:** Features, models, and pricing may change. What you read today may shift in the coming months. Stay connected to Anthropic's announcements and educator communities.
- **District Approval:** Many districts are still developing their AI policies. Claude may not yet be approved for use in your district, especially for student-facing applications.

What's Coming Next

The landscape of AI in education is evolving rapidly. Here are developments to watch:

- **Deeper Integrations:** Claude's integration with Google Workspace and other tools will continue to deepen, potentially including direct LMS connections.
- **Expanded Cowork Capabilities:** Cowork is in research preview and being actively developed. Expect more Skills, better file handling, and more autonomous workflow management.
- **Education-Specific Plans:** Anthropic has indicated that education-specific pricing and features are in development, which could make Claude more accessible for schools and districts.
- **Agentic Workflows:** The future of Claude in education is not just answering questions but taking on entire workflows: managing your assessment cycle, maintaining your curriculum map, or coordinating differentiated instruction across a grade-level team.
- **Responsible AI Policy:** As more states and districts formalize their AI policies, expect clearer guidance on what is and is not appropriate for educator and student use.

Final Thoughts

You became a teacher to make a difference in the lives of young people. Somewhere along the way, the profession loaded you with hours of administrative work that pull you away from that purpose. Claude does not make you a better teacher — you are already a good teacher. Claude gives you time back so that your skill, your passion, and your presence can show up where they matter most: in your interactions with students.

Start small. Be curious. Protect your students. And remember that every minute Claude saves you on planning is a minute you can spend on the human work that no AI will ever replace.

Created by The Rooted Learner

therootedlearner.com

Empowering educators to teach smarter with AI

© 2026 The Rooted Learner. All rights reserved.